“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 18

The Fall into the Ocean

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 Once, seeing the ocean in the light of the autumn moon, Śrī Śacīnandana took it for the Yamunā and ran towards it. He plunged into its waters as if into an ocean of the burning pain of separation from Hari, and lay there unconscious the whole night; at dawn His own devotees found Him. May that son of Śacī protect us here.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 In this way Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala, floating night and day in the ocean of separation from Kṛṣṇa.

4 It was an autumn night, bright everywhere with moonlight, and the Lord spent the whole night roaming with His companions.[2]

5 He wandered from garden to garden, delighting in their wonders, reciting and hearing songs and verses about the rāsa dance.

6 Absorbed in love, the Lord sang and danced, and at times, in that same rapture, He enacted the *rāsa-līlā*.

7 Sometimes, in the madness of ecstatic feeling, the Lord ran here and there; sometimes He fell to the ground and swooned, and sometimes He rolled about.

8 Whenever He recited or heard a verse about the *rāsa-līlā*, He Himself would explain its meaning, as before.

9 In this way He explained the meaning of every verse about the *rāsa-līlā*, feeling now joy, now sorrow.[3]

10 To describe the meaning of all those verses and all those ecstatic transformations would make the book far too long.

11 For fear of excessive length, I have not written down all the pastimes that took place moment by moment during those twelve years.

12 As before, I have only pointed the way; understand this description of His ecstatic transformations and ravings in the same way.

13 Even if Ananta were to describe them with His thousand mouths, He could not reach the end of the pastimes of a single day.

14 Even if Gaṇeśa were to write for ten million ages, he could not come to the end of the pastimes of a single day.

15 Seeing the transformations of love in His devotee, even Kṛṣṇa is struck with wonder! If Kṛṣṇa Himself cannot find their end, what hope is there for any lesser being?

16–17 Kṛṣṇa cannot fully know all the states of His devotee's love, its courses and its kinds, all its sorrow, all its happiness and all its transformations. So, to taste them, He accepts the mood of a devotee.[4]

18 Love makes Kṛṣṇa dance and makes the devotee dance, and it dances itself: all three dance together in one place.

19 Whoever wants to describe the transformations of love is like a dwarf who wants to catch the moon.

20 As the wind carries off a single drop of the ocean's water, so a living being can touch only a drop of love for Kṛṣṇa.

21 Moment by moment endless waves of love rise up. How could an insignificant living being ever find their end?

22 Only Svarūpa and the others of His inner circle know what Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya tasted.[5]

23 When a mere living being describes it, he touches but a single drop of it, to purify himself.

24 In this way the Lord recited all the verses about the rāsa dance, and at the end He began to recite a verse about the water pastimes:

25 "Weary, Kṛṣṇa entered the water with the gopīs to relieve His fatigue, as a king of elephants who has broken through the dikes enters the water with his she-elephants; for He too had passed beyond the bounds of worldly convention. His garland, crushed by the contact of their bodies, was reddened with *kuṅkuma* from the gopīs' breasts, and bees followed Him, singing like the lords of the Gandharvas." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.33.22)[6]

26 Wandering about in this way, Mahāprabhu suddenly saw the ocean from Āiṭoṭā.

27 The surging waves, bright in the moonlight, glittered like the waters of the Yamunā.

28 Taking it for the Yamunā, the Lord ran towards it and, unnoticed by anyone, leapt into the ocean.

29 As soon as He fell in, He swooned and knew nothing. The waves now sank Him beneath the water, now raised Him to the surface.

30 Carried by the waves, He drifted about like a dry log. Who can understand this wondrous dance of Caitanya?

31 The waves carried the Lord towards Koṇārka, sometimes keeping Him under the water, sometimes bearing Him along on the surface.[7]

32 Kṛṣṇa was enjoying water pastimes with the gopīs in the Yamunā, and Mahāprabhu was absorbed in that play.[8]

33 Meanwhile Svarūpa and the others, not seeing the Lord, cried out in alarm, "Where has the Lord gone?"

34 The Lord had gone with the speed of the mind, and no one saw Him go. With Him nowhere to be seen, they began to wonder:

35 "Has He gone to see Jagannātha, or to some other temple? Into another garden? Or has He fallen down somewhere in His madness?

36 Has He gone to the Guṇḍicā temple, or to Narendra Lake? To the Caṭaka hill, or to Koṇārka?"

37 Saying this, they all went about looking for the Lord, and then came to the seashore, taking a few others with them.

38 In this search the night came to an end, and they concluded, "The Lord has departed."[9]

39 In separation from the Lord they all felt as if life had left their bodies, and no one could think of anything but the fear that some harm had come to Him.

40 “The hearts of those who love always fear some harm.” (Abhijñāna-śakuntala, Act 4)[10]

41 Coming to the seashore, they took counsel together, and some of them went towards the Cirāyu hill.[11]

42 Svarūpa went east with a few others, searching for the Lord along the shore and in the waters of the sea.

43 They were all overwhelmed with grief and hardly conscious, yet, moved by love, they kept on searching for Him.

44 Then they saw a fisherman coming along with his net on his shoulder. He was laughing, weeping, dancing and singing, and saying, “Hari! Hari!”

45 Everyone was astonished to see how the fisherman was behaving, and Svarūpa Gosāñi asked him what had happened:

46 “Tell us, fisherman, have you seen someone around here? And why are you in such a state? Tell us the reason.”

47 The fisherman said, “I have not seen a single person here. But as I was drawing in my net, a dead body came into it.

48 Thinking it was a big fish, I hauled it up with great effort, but when I saw the corpse my heart was filled with fear.

49 As I was freeing the net, I touched his body, and at that very touch the spirit entered my heart.[12]

50 I began to tremble with fear, tears flowed from my eyes, my voice choked, and all my hair stood on end.

51 Whether it is a *brahma-daitya* or a spirit, I cannot say, but the moment anyone sees it, it enters his body.

52 His body is long — five or seven cubits — and each of his arms and legs is three cubits long.

53 The joints of his bones have come loose, and his skin hangs slack. Who could see that and not have the life frightened out of him?

54 He lies there like a corpse, his eyes turned upward. Sometimes he makes a sound — "goṅ, goṅ" — and sometimes I see him lying unconscious.

55 I have seen him with my own eyes, and that spirit has seized me. If I die, how will my wife and children live?

56 That spirit is beyond describing. I am going to an exorcist — perhaps he can drive the spirit out.

57 I wander alone at night, catching fish in lonely places, yet spirits and ghosts do not touch me, because I remember Nṛsiṁha.

58 But at the name of Nṛsiṁha this spirit presses on me twice as hard. The mere sight of his form fills my mind with fear.

59 Do not go there — I forbid you! If you go there, that spirit will seize you all."

60 Hearing this, Svarūpa Gosāñi understood the whole truth and spoke to the fisherman in sweet words:

61 "I am a great exorcist; I know how to drive out spirits." Reciting a mantra, he placed his holy hand on the fisherman's head.[13]

62 Then he slapped the fisherman three times and calmed him, saying, "The spirit has fled. Do not be afraid!"

63 Love on the one hand and fear on the other had made him doubly restless. Now that the fear was gone, he recovered himself a little.

64 Svarūpa said, "The one you take for a spirit is no spirit at all. He is Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, the Supreme Lord.

65 Absorbed in love, He fell into the sea, and you hauled Him up in your net.

66 By His touch love for Kṛṣṇa awoke in you, but because you thought He was a spirit or a ghost, you were seized by great fear.

67 Now the fear has gone, and your mind is calm. Show me where you hauled Him up."

68 The fisherman said, "I have seen the Lord many times. That is not Him — this one has a terribly distorted form."

69 Svarūpa said, "These are transformations of love in Him: the joints of His bones come apart, and His body grows very long."

70 Hearing this, the fisherman was delighted. He took them all along and showed them Mahāprabhu.

71 He was lying on the ground, His whole body elongated, white from the water and covered with sand.

72 His body was very long and slack, and its skin hung loose. It was impossible to lift Him and carry Him so far.

73 They removed His wet loincloth and dressed Him in a dry one, brushed off the sand and laid Him on His outer cloth.[14]

74 Then all of them together began loud saṅkīrtana, chanting the name of Kṛṣṇa loudly into the Lord's ear.

75 After some time the sound reached His ears, and with a mighty cry He at once rose up.

76 As soon as He stood up, all His bones returned to their places, and in half-external consciousness He looked all around.

77 Mahāprabhu was always in one of three states: the internal state, the external state, and the half-external.

78 When something of the absorption of the internal state remains along with some external awareness, the devotees call that state "half-external."[15]

79 In the half-external state the Lord spoke in ravings, as if to the sky, and the devotees listened:

80 "Seeing the Kālindī, I went to Vṛndāvana, and I see the son of the king of Vraja playing in the water.

81 Together with Rādhikā and the other gopīs He is enjoying His pastimes in the waters of the Yamunā with great delight.

82 Standing on the bank with the sakhīs, I watch, and one sakhī points out that play to the others.[16]

83 Handing their silk garments and ornaments to the sakhīs and dressed in fine white cloth, Kṛṣṇa and His beloveds went down into the water, and He began delightful water pastimes.[17]

84 O sakhī, see the play of Kṛṣṇa's water pastimes! Like a maddened lord of elephants, His lotus hands never still, Kṛṣṇa has taken the gopīs with Him.[18]

85 The water play began. They splashed one another; there was a tumult, and water rained down in streams. No one could tell who was winning and who was losing, and the battle in the water raged beyond all bounds.

86 The steady flashes of lightning rained water on the dark new cloud, and the cloud rained upon the lightning. The eyes of the sakhīs, like thirsty *cātakī* birds, drank that nectar with joy.[19]

87 First they fought water against water, then hand against hand, after that face to face, then chest to chest; then came a battle of words, and last of all a battle of nails.[20]

88 With a thousand hands He sprinkled water, with a thousand eyes He looked at the gopīs, with a thousand feet He drew near them, with a thousand mouths He kissed them, with a thousand bodies He embraced them, and with a thousand ears He heard the gopīs' playful jests.

89 Kṛṣṇa drew Rādhā by force into neck-deep water and let Her go where it was fathomless. Clasping Kṛṣṇa's neck, She floated on the water like a lotus plant uprooted by an elephant.

90 Assuming as many forms as there were beautiful cowherd girls, Kṛṣṇa took away all their garments. Their bodies shimmered in the clear water of the Yamunā, and He gazed on them with joy.

91 The lotus creepers, like a host of sakhīs, came to the help of some of them, placing leaves in their hands. Some let down their hair, which covered them in front like a lower garment, and for others their own hands became a bodice.[21]

92 When Kṛṣṇa began a quarrel with Rādhā, the gopīs at once went to hide among the golden lotuses. They sank into the water up to their necks, so that only their faces showed, and I could not tell those faces from the lotuses.

93 Meanwhile Kṛṣṇa, alone with Rādhā, did as He had wished and then went to look for the gopīs. Then perceptive Rādhā, knowing where Her sakhīs were hiding, came and mingled among them.

94 As many golden lotuses as floated on the water, so many blue lotuses came up beside them, and every blue lotus that met a golden one did battle with it; the sakhīs watched from the bank with delight.[22]

95 A flock of *cakravāka* birds rose from the water, pair by pair. Then a cluster of lotuses rose, pair by pair, and covered the *cakravākas*.[23]

96 Next many red water lilies (*utpala*) rose, pair by pair, and warded off the lotuses. The lotuses wanted to carry off the *cakravākas* as plunder, and the water lilies wanted to protect them; so for the sake of the *cakravākas* the two fought.

97 Lotuses and water lilies are insentient, while *cakravākas* are sentient; yet here the lotuses taste the *cakravākas*. The positions of the two are re-

versed, and their natures have turned into their opposites: such is the rule in Kṛṣṇa's kingdom.

98 The lotus comes and plunders the *cakravāka*, its neighbour and the friend of its own friend, the sun — such is the way in Kṛṣṇa's kingdom. And the water lily protects the friend of its enemy, the sun, though it does not even know him — a great wonder! This is the great ornament called "contradiction" (*virodha*).[24]

99 Thus Kṛṣṇa openly displayed two figures of speech, hyperbole (*atiśayokti*) and apparent contradiction (*virodhābhāsa*). As I tasted them, My mind was delighted, and My eyes and ears were refreshed.[25]

100 After such wonderful play Śrī Hari came up onto the bank with all His beloveds, and there the sakhīs served Them, massaging Them with fragrant oil and rubbing Them with *āmalakī* paste.[26]

101 Then They bathed again, put on dry clothes and came to a jewelled pavilion. There Vṛndā had prepared fragrances, flowers and ornaments for Them, and They put on forest attire.

102 The trees and creepers of Vṛndāvana are wonderful indeed: all twelve months of the year they bear flowers and fruits. The goddesses of the forest and all the maidservants of the bowers picked the fruits and brought them.

103 They prepared the fruits with great care, filled large platters with them and set these out in rows on a raised dais in the jewelled pavilion, in the order in which they were to be eaten; and in front they placed seats.

104 There were coconuts of many kinds and mangoes of many sorts, bananas and jujubes of various kinds, jackfruits, dates, oranges, tangerines,

jāma fruits, pomelos (*sāntārā*), grapes, almonds, and all kinds of dried fruits and nuts.[27]

105 Melons, *kṣīrikā* cucumbers, palm fruits, *keśura* roots, water chestnuts, lotus stalks, *bilva*, *pīlu*, pomegranates and many more — whatever fruit is famous in any land is found in Vṛndāvana. There are a thousand kinds; how many can be written down?

106 *Gaṅgājala*, *amṛtakeli*, *pīyūṣagranthi*, *karpūrakeli*, *sarapūrī*, *amṛti*, *padmacini*, and little trees made of sugar and *kṣīrisāra* — all these various sweets Rādhā had made at home and brought for Kṛṣṇa.[28]

107 Seeing how finely the food was arranged, Kṛṣṇa was delighted and sat down to the forest meal. Then Rādhā ate with Her sakhīs, and the two of Them lay down to rest in the pavilion.

108 Some fanned Them, some massaged Their feet, some gave Them betel to chew. Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa fell asleep, and the sakhīs lay down too. My heart was happy to see it.

109 Just then you all seized Me, made a great uproar and brought Me here. Where is the Yamunā now, where is Vṛndāvana? Where are Kṛṣṇa and the gopīs? You have broken My happiness!”[29]

110 As He said this, the Lord came fully back to external consciousness. Seeing Svarūpa Gosāñi, He asked him,

111 “Why have you brought Me here?” Then Svarūpa Gosāñi began to speak:

112 “Taking the ocean for the Yamunā, You fell into it, and the waves carried You this far!

113 This fisherman hauled You up in his net, and by Your touch he became mad with love.

114 All night long we wandered about searching for You; then we heard the fisherman's story, came here and found You.

115 You seem to have swooned, yet You are watching pastimes in Vṛndāvana. But we, seeing You unconscious, suffer with all our hearts.

116 When we chanted the name of Kṛṣṇa, You came to half-external consciousness, and we heard Your ravings."

117 The Lord said, "I dreamt that I had gone to Vṛndāvana, and there I see Kṛṣṇa dancing the rāsa with the gopīs.

118 After the water pastimes He enjoyed a forest meal. Seeing all this, I suppose I spoke in ravings."

119 Then Svarūpa Gosāñi bathed the Lord and, overjoyed, brought Him home.

120 Thus I have told of the Lord's fall into the ocean. Whoever hears this attains the feet of Caitanya.[30]

121 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. Heading in the edition: a prayer for the mercy of the Lord who, in separation from Kṛṣṇa, drifts on the ocean, having taken it for the Yamunā. *Anubhāṣya*: "His own" — His most intimate devotees. ↩

2. Heading in the edition: the moonlit autumn night awakens (*uddīpana*) the feelings of the *rāsa-līlā*. ↩
3. *Anubhāṣya*: joy in the pastimes of union (*sambhoga*) of Kṛṣṇa, sorrow in the pastimes of separation (*vipralambha*) of the gopīs. ↩
4. Heading in the edition: to understand the love of the gopīs and to know the measure of its taste, Kṛṣṇa accepts the feeling of a gopī. ↩
5. Heading in the edition: only Svarūpa, Rāma Rāya and the others — the host of Kṛṣṇa's potencies — can enter into the feelings of the Lord. ↩
6. *Anubhāṣya*: "having broken the dikes" (*bhinna-setuḥ*) is said both of the king of elephants and of Kṛṣṇa — Bhagavān Himself, who passes beyond the bounds of worldly convention; the bees sing like the lords of the Gandharvas (*gandharva-pāḥ*). ↩
7. *Anubhāṣya*: Koṇārka stands on the seashore, nineteen miles north of Purī, where a temple of the Sun was built of black stone, a masterpiece of architecture. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Koṇārka is Arka-tīrtha. ↩
8. Heading in the edition: the *udghūrṇā* of the Lord, absorbed in feeling and thinking Himself a maidservant of the gopīs. The *Anubhāṣya* refers to verses 80–82. ↩
9. Heading in the edition: not finding the Lord, they conclude that He has departed (*antarddhāna*). ↩
10. Heading in the edition: when the beloved is not seen, the loving heart fears harm; these are the words of Priyaṁvadā to Śakuntalā. ↩
11. *Anubhāṣya*: the Cirāyu hill is the Caṭaka hill (36). ↩
12. Heading in the edition (from 46): the fisherman, "possessed by a spirit", tells of the Lord and His state. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: at the touch of the Lord the fisherman was seized by divine love (*premāveśa*), but he took it for a spirit that had entered him. ↩
13. Heading in the edition: Svarūpa reassures the fisherman and frees him from fear. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: with a clap of Kṛṣṇa's name Svarūpa drove the "spirit" — that is, his fear — out of the fisherman. ↩
14. Heading in the edition: efforts and service to bring the Lord back to consciousness. ↩
15. Heading in the edition: the half-external consciousness of the Lord, who regards Himself as a maidservant of the gopīs (*citra-jalpa*). ↩
16. *Anubhāṣya*: the sakhīs are "I and others like Me" — young maidservants (*mañjarīs*), each wholly devoted to the joy of serving her own group leader (*yūtheśvarī*); this rules out *ahaṅgrahopāsanā*, the practitioner's worship of himself as God. ↩

17. Heading in the edition: regarding Himself as a maidservant of the gopīs, the Lord describes Kṛṣṇa's water pastimes with Śrī Rādhā and the other gopīs (*citra-jalpa*). ↩
18. The line "O sakhī, see…" is marked in the edition as a refrain (*dhruva*). *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *kara-puṣkara* — lotus hands; according to another opinion, the tip of the trunk. ↩
19. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the gopīs, like steady flashes of lightning, showered water on Kṛṣṇa, dark as a new cloud, and the cloud — Kṛṣṇa — showered water back upon the lightning. ↩
20. The *Anubhāṣya* gives a variant reading: *radā-radi* ("tooth against tooth") for *hṛdā-hṛdi* ("chest to chest"). ↩
21. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: a lotus leaf served them like a hand to cover the body; some let down their hair and imagined it a lower garment, and others made a bodice of their hands. The *Anubhāṣya* gives a variant reading: "made a bodice in a svastika" — apparently, with arms crossed over the breast. ↩
22. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the golden lotuses are the gopīs, and the blue lotuses Kṛṣṇa; the sakhīs, devoted to service, watched their play from the bank. ↩
23. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* (on 95–98): the *cakravākas* are the breasts of the gopīs, the blue lotuses are Kṛṣṇa's hands, and the red water lilies are the gopīs' hands, which protect the *cakravākas*. Ordinarily the *cakravāka* bird feeds on the lotus, but in this play of Kṛṣṇa the insentient lotus tastes the sentient *cakravāka*: their natures are reversed. ↩
24. *Anubhāṣya*: the sun is the lotus's friend, for at sunrise the lotus opens and the *cakravākas* are reunited; but at sunrise the *utpala* closes, so the sun is its enemy, and the *cakravāka* is a stranger to it, since it blooms at night. The lotus — Kṛṣṇa's hand — attacking the *cakravāka* — the gopī's breast — is "apparent contradiction" (*virodhābhāsa*); the *utpala* — the gopī's hand — protecting the *cakravāka* is "contradiction" (*virodha*). ↩
25. *Anubhāṣya*: *atiśayokti* (hyperbole) is naming the object of comparison in place of the thing compared, in the firm conviction that they are one (*Sāhitya-darpaṇa*, ch. 10); *virodhābhāsa* (apparent contradiction) is speaking of what involves no contradiction as though it were contradictory (*Kāvya-prakāśa*, ch. 10). ↩
26. Heading in the edition: the varied service rendered to Śrī Kṛṣṇa by the transcendental (*aprākṛta*) *mañjarīs* together with the gopīs. ↩
27. *Anubhāṣya*: *koli* — the jujube (*badarī*); *sāntārā* — a large citrus like the pomelo; *meoyā* — pistachios, almonds and other choice fruits of cold lands. ↩

28. *Anubhāṣya*: *gaṅgājala* and the rest are sweet balls and various cakes made of curd (*chānā*) with sugar; *khaṇḍa-kṣīrisāra* — sugar sweets shaped like trees. ↩
29. Heading in the edition: the Lord longs for Kṛṣṇa's happiness. ↩
30. Heading in the edition: whoever hears of this *mahābhāva* of the Lord, even one bereft of consciousness (*acaitanya*), gains consciousness (*caitanya*) — turning towards Kṛṣṇa. ↩